

SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

Social and Political Ideals - Solved Practice Workbook

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

LEARNING PATH



Deterministic fallback visual: move from precise concepts through argument and critique to exam application.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

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Major learning parts and meaningful subtopics are listed in document order. Page numbers are generated from the final PDF layout; PDF bookmarks mirror the same hierarchy.

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Social and Political Ideals - Solved Practice Workbook

Standalone workbook. It reproduces the complete practice apparatus of the Social and Political Ideals learning package and can be worked without the teaching sessions. Syllabus, verbatim: *Social and Political Ideals : Equality, Justice, Liberty*. - UPSC Philosophy Paper II, Section A, item 1. □ Three ideals are printed and only three; democracy, rights and duties, sovereignty, welfare and reservation policy belong to later owners and appear here only where they execute the triad. **Evidence discipline:** FACT: doctrine on which the standard sources converge · ANALYSIS: analytical reconstruction for exam use · CAUTION: a live scholarly dispute. Model answers are independent learner practice and are never official UPSC keys; UPSC publishes no descriptive model answer for Philosophy Paper II. **Terminology and citation rule:** the English concept leads and the technical term follows immediately in parentheses - *equal moral worth (equal concern and respect)*, *a fair starting line (equality of opportunity)*, *need-sensitive differential treatment (equity)*, *differences made by convention (moral, political or artificial inequality)*, *freedom from interference (negative liberty)*, *freedom to be one's own master (positive liberty)*, *freedom as a secured standing (non-domination)*, *what a person is actually able to do and to be (capability)*, *consistent application of announced rules (formal justice)*, *fairness of the deciding process (procedural justice)*, *justice of the standard itself (substantive justice)*, *shares proportioned to relevant desert (proportional equality)*, *equal units restored to each side (arithmetic equality)*, *the fair choice situation (original position)*, *ignorance of one's own advantages (veil of ignorance)*, *justice judged by how holdings arose (historical or entitlement theory)*, *correctness of institutions and rules (nīti)*, *justice as it is actually realised in people's lives (nyāya)*. Provenance is examinable: **Mill 1859** for *On Liberty* and **1869** for *The Subjection of Women*; **Berlin 1958**; **Rawls 1971**; **Nozick 1974**; **Pettit 1997** for the normative theory of non-domination and **Skinner 1998** for its historical recovery. No page, chapter, edition or quotation is attached to any of them.

What this workbook contains

Component	Count
Original diagnostic MCQs - 24 core plus 8 remedial drills	32
Question-specific option explanations	128
Unique examiner traps	32
Directly owned verified PYQs solved in full, 2018-2025	14
Original solved Mains models - two each at 10, 15 and 20 marks	6

How to use it

1. Attempt the twenty-four core MCQs without notes, then read every option explanation, including those for the options you rejected. The key sequence is **unpatterned** - each answer was fixed independently - so no cycle can be guessed, and option lengths are matched so that the answer cannot be spotted by shape.
2. Work the eight remedial drills only after the core set. They target the confluences, inversions, misattributions and ownership errors that cost marks every year on this clause.
3. Attempt each previous-year part under time before reading its solution. **Decide the demanded ideal from the stem first:** four owned parts are equality parts, four are liberty parts, five are justice parts, and two are composite parts requiring all three.
4. Write the six original models in full. Two are 10-mark, two 15-mark and two 20-mark, and each sits inside the declared word band - **10 marks about 150 to 220 words, 15 marks about 250 to 330, 20 marks about 330 to 400**.
5. Check every answer against the traps: equality read as sameness, Berlin read as anti-positive, Mill read as licence, Rawls written with equality first, Nozick called a patterned theorist, Sen reduced to welfare economics, Ambedkar used as a name-drop, and any script that imports democratic institutional forms, Marxism as an ideology, or reservation policy from another owner.

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

32 original MCQs - 24 core diagnostics and 8 remedial error-targeting drills

Answer placement: each correct option was fixed **independently**, so the key sequence is unpatterned rather than rotated and no cycle such as ABCD - or its reverse - can be used to guess. Options are matched for length, specificity, grammar and visible formatting so that the answer cannot be spotted by shape alone. Every question carries four question-specific option explanations and one unique examiner trap.

Coverage: the twenty-four core questions run across the whole printed clause - *Equality, Justice, Liberty* - together with the ordering problem, the four forms of equality, formal against fair equality of opportunity and the defensible version of the outcome demand, Rousseau's two inequalities and the conversion mechanism, Mill's six salient features with the qualification that limits them, the Marxian equity/equality contrast and the two-stage structure of the need formula, the "equality of what" dispute across Sen, Cohen and Dworkin, Berlin's two concepts with the real-self mechanism, the harm principle as a burden-of-proof rule, the four rival specifications of freedom arranged by the enemy each fears, the threshold of complementarity, the migration of coercion from law to architecture, the interference/domination distinction and the freedom-constituting reading of law, the three forms and four dimensions of justice, and Aristotle's two equalities. The eight remedial drills attack the errors that cost marks every year on this clause: collapsing merit into desert, ignoring the terminus and over-inclusion problems in compensation, inverting Rawls's priority order, historicising the original position, calling Nozick a patterned theorist while forgetting rectification, translating *nīti* and *nyāya* loosely, misattributing the republican theory and misdating Mill's two books, and importing material owned by Forms of Government, Political Ideologies or the caste file.

MCQ 1. Why justice is called the ordering or architectonic ideal

The syllabus prints three ideals. On the account developed in this package, what exactly makes justice the ordering ideal rather than simply the third item in a list?

- A. Justice is historically the oldest of the three ideals and therefore has priority over the other two.
- B. Justice is the only one of the three that a written constitution is capable of guaranteeing to citizens.
- C. Liberty and equality are each indeterminate about their own variants, so the ranking must be supplied from outside either one.
- D. Justice replaces liberty and equality once institutions become sufficiently developed and stable.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: chronological priority is not normative priority, and the claim would in any case be unusable, since all three ideals are discussed in ancient political thought.
- **B:** Incorrect: constitutions can guarantee legal and political equality and basic liberties too; the argument turns on indeterminacy, not on what a legal text can enact.
- **C:** Correct: liberty does not say *which* liberties are basic and equality does not say *which* equality is owed, so a ranking between them must range over both - and that ranging criterion is what "justice" names here.
- **D:** Incorrect: nothing in the ordering claim is developmental, and justice orders the other two ideals rather than superseding them.

Examiner trap 1: Writing that justice "balances" liberty and equality without saying what makes balancing possible converts a structural argument into a platitude; the marks are in the indeterminacy premise, not in the word "balance".

MCQ 2. What the foundational claim of equality actually asserts

Which statement gives the foundational premise of equality as a political ideal with the precision the paper rewards?

- A. Persons possess equal moral worth, so arbitrary hierarchies require justification rather than presumption.
- B. Persons possess identical talents and capacities, so differential treatment is always without foundation.
- C. Persons should receive identical incomes, since any income difference reflects an arbitrary social hierarchy.
- D. Persons should never have their relevant differences recognised by law, policy or public institutions.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: the premise is normative, concerning the standing institutions must accord, and its immediate consequence is the shifted burden of justification.
- **B:** Incorrect: equality of worth is expressly distinguished from identity of talent, desire, capacity or outcome; asserting identity makes the ideal refutable by observation.
- **C:** Incorrect: equality before the law does not entail equal income; economic equality is one contested form among four, not the foundational claim.
- **D:** Incorrect: recognising *relevant* difference is required by proportional justice; equality denies that difference by itself authorises domination.

Examiner trap 2: Defining equality as sameness and then refuting the definition wastes half the answer attacking a position no serious egalitarian holds.

MCQ 3. What each of the four forms of equality secures

Match the form of equality with what it is designed to secure. Which pairing is correct?

- A. Formal or legal equality secures equal civic respect by removing stigma and status hierarchy from society.
- B. Political equality secures fair background conditions by reducing disparities of wealth and life chances.
- C. Social equality secures the rule against legal privilege by guaranteeing equal protection of the laws.
- D. Economic equality secures fair background conditions; social equality secures equal civic respect.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: it transfers social equality's function to the legal form; formal equality secures the rule against legal privilege.
- **B:** Incorrect: political equality secures a non-oligarchic public standing through equal citizenship, vote and eligibility for office, not background material conditions.
- **C:** Incorrect: this reverses the pairing again, assigning the legal form's achievement to the social form.
- **D:** Correct: economic equality targets disparities in resources, wealth and life chances, while social equality targets status hierarchy, stigma and humiliation.

Examiner trap 3: Treating the four forms as four synonyms for one ideal loses the analytic structure; each form secures a different thing and fails to a different objection, and a two-column table earns more than a paragraph of praise.

MCQ 4. The move that saves equality of opportunity from its own objection

The objection to equality of opportunity is that "starting-line" fairness is illusory where background inequality is severe. What is the standard reply?

- A. Abandon opportunity language entirely and evaluate institutions by the equality of their final distributions.
- B. Move from merely formal equality of opportunity to fair equality of opportunity, which attends to background conditions.
- C. Restrict the demand for opportunity to political offices, leaving education, health and employment untouched.
- D. Accept that opportunity can never be equal, and therefore treat the ideal as purely aspirational rhetoric.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the reply preserves opportunity language; it is the outcome camp, not the opportunity camp, that relocates fairness to the finishing line.
- **B:** Correct: the fair version asks whether persons of similar talent and willingness have similar prospects regardless of social origin, which converts opportunity from a property of the rule into a property of background conditions.
- **C:** Incorrect: narrowing the scope concedes the objection wholesale, since the preparation problem bites hardest in exactly the excluded areas.
- **D:** Incorrect: this abandons the ideal rather than repairing it, and it is inconsistent with Rawls's inclusion of fair equality of opportunity as an operative principle.

Examiner trap 4: Treating "equality of opportunity" as automatically the moderate, uncontroversial position ignores that merely formal opportunity is compatible with an almost perfectly closed society.

MCQ 5. The defensible version of the equality-of-outcome demand

Egalitarians are accused of demanding identical outcomes and thereby destroying incentive. What is the defensible form of the outcome demand?

- A. Every person receives an identical share of every social good, irrespective of contribution or need.
- B. Outcomes are equalised across all spheres so that no measurable difference of any kind survives.
- C. Incomes are equalised annually, with any residual difference redistributed by administrative decision.
- D. Ceilings on avoidable deprivation and floors of decent capability, rather than identical final holdings.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: identical shares are the caricature the levelling objection defeats, and almost no egalitarian defends them across all goods.
- **B:** Incorrect: eliminating all measurable difference is neither proposed nor coherent, since goods differ in kind as well as amount.
- **C:** Incorrect: annual administrative equalisation is a policy fantasy, not a philosophical position, and it maximises rather than answers the paternalism objection.
- **D:** Correct: the serious demand is threshold-based - a floor of decent capability and a ceiling on avoidable deprivation - which is why the honest objection is that the threshold is under-specified.

Examiner trap 5: Refuting flat levelling and declaring the outcome view defeated leaves the actual position untouched, and it forfeits the marks available for identifying the threshold problem.

MCQ 6. Rousseau's distinction, stated exactly

How does Rousseau distinguish natural from moral or political inequality?

- A. Natural inequality concerns wealth and rank, while moral inequality concerns strength, health and intelligence.
- B. Natural inequality is unjust and remediable, while moral inequality is just because convention has authorised it.
- C. Natural inequality covers age, strength, health and intelligence; moral inequality is established by convention.
- D. Natural inequality exists only before society, and moral inequality disappears once property is abolished.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: it reverses the two categories exactly, and the reversal makes the political argument unintelligible.
- **B:** Incorrect: Rousseau's point is the opposite - conventional inequality is the form that stands most in need of justification, not the form authorised by convention.
- **C:** Correct: physical differences are established by nature, while wealth, honour, power, dependence and social superiority are established by convention.
- **D:** Incorrect: it adds a claim about abolition that the distinction does not make; the argument is diagnostic about the conversion of difference into domination.

Examiner trap 6: Confusing natural inequality with natural *rightlessness* imports a claim Rousseau never makes; natural inequality concerns bodies and talents, never standing.

MCQ 7. What Rousseau's distinction does not assert

Which statement correctly identifies the limit of Rousseau's claim?

- A. He does not claim that all inequality is conventional, only that the most oppressive forms are socially produced and maintained.
- B. He does not claim that property plays any role in producing dependence, since dependence is a natural human condition.
- C. He does not claim that institutions can magnify natural differences, since institutions merely register what nature supplies.
- D. He does not claim that social comparison matters, because comparison belongs to psychology rather than to politics.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: the thesis is that oppressive inequality is socially produced and socially maintained, which is precisely what makes it socially remediable.
- **B:** Incorrect: property and social comparison are the two named mechanisms by which civil society deepens dependence.
- **C:** Incorrect: the conversion of natural difference into durable domination by institutions is the core of the argument, not an addition to it.
- **D:** Incorrect: comparison is treated as politically consequential, since it is one of the mechanisms that produce vanity and hierarchy.

Examiner trap 7: Writing the 2021 answer as a narrative of the state of nature misses the demand: the stem asks how he *distinguishes* the two inequalities, so the contrast and the conversion mechanism carry the marks.

MCQ 8. The qualification that completes Mill's account of equality

Mill is described as a liberal egalitarian "in a qualified sense". What is the qualification?

- A. He rejects equality before the law wherever custom has long sanctioned a difference of social station.
- B. He resists crude levelling that suppresses individuality, and stops short of extinguishing all differences by coercive equalisation.
- C. He restricts equal moral standing to citizens who have already achieved a specified level of education.
- D. He accepts inherited social subordination provided that it demonstrably increases aggregate social utility.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: privilege by status is exactly what he calls indefensible; equality before the law is among his affirmed features.
- **B:** Correct: he affirms equal moral standing, equal civic and legal status and women's equality, while treating free self-development rather than sameness as the goal.
- **C:** Incorrect: no educational threshold conditions equal moral standing in the six salient features.
- **D:** Incorrect: he holds that inherited subordination blocks both utility and justice, so the utilitarian route to accepting it is closed.

Examiner trap 8: Listing five features and omitting the limit answers a different question; on a "salient features" stem it is the qualification that separates a good script from an average one.

MCQ 9. The structure of Mill's argument about the subjection of women

Mill argues that the subordination of women is not justified by nature. What is the structure of his reason?

- A. Nature is irrelevant to political questions, so no appeal to nature can support or oppose any social arrangement.
- B. The "nature" appealed to is itself socially manufactured through subjection, so the evidence is produced by the system under examination.
- C. Women's capacities exceed men's in the relevant respects, so the hierarchy inverts the ordering that nature actually supports.
- D. Utility is the only test of institutions, so questions about nature never arise in evaluating the subordination of women.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: this is a general methodological claim Mill does not need; his argument is specific and evidential.
- **B:** Correct: the appeal to women's nature is worthless as evidence precisely because that nature has been produced by the subjection it is invoked to justify.
- **C:** Incorrect: the argument does not assert an inverted natural hierarchy; it disqualifies the evidence on which any such hierarchy is claimed.
- **D:** Incorrect: Mill does argue from utility as well, but the specific answer to the appeal-to-nature defence is the manufactured-evidence point.

Examiner trap 9: Dating the feminist argument to *On Liberty* costs an easy mark: *On Liberty* is **1859** and *The Subjection of Women* is **1869**.

MCQ 10. The Marxian contrast between equity and equality

With reference to Marxian philosophy, which formulation states the difference between equity and equality correctly?

- A. Equality means distribution by need, while equity means the same measure applied to every producer.
- B. Equality means abolishing the wage relation, while equity means preserving it under stricter public regulation.
- C. Equality and equity are interchangeable terms, differing only in the historical period in which each was used.
- D. Equality is the same measure for all; equity is differentiated treatment responsive to need and actual condition.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: it inverts the pair; the need-based formula belongs to equity, and the common standard belongs to formal equality.
- **B:** Incorrect: abolition of the wage relation is part of the wider critique, not the definition of either term.
- **C:** Incorrect: the whole force of the 2022 stem depends on the two terms being distinct.
- **D:** Correct: the same measure applied to persons with unequal needs, burdens and starting positions produces unequal effect, which is why equity is the more demanding ideal.

Examiner trap 10: Answering the equity/equality stem with an essay on historical materialism substitutes the ideology owner's material for the demanded concept.

MCQ 11. "An equal right can be a right of inequality"

What does the Marxian claim that equal right is a right of inequality assert?

- A. One common standard applied to persons differing in need, burden and starting position guarantees unequal effect.
- B. Legal rights are worthless because law is nothing more than an instrument of the economically dominant class.
- C. Rights should be abolished in favour of administrative allocation supervised by producers themselves.
- D. Equality is a bourgeois invention with no application at any stage of social and economic development.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: the defect is in the measure - a single common standard abstracts from precisely the differences that decide whether a share is adequate.
- **B:** Incorrect: this substitutes a general claim about law for the specific argument about the structure of an equal measure.
- **C:** Incorrect: no such administrative proposal is contained in the equity/equality contrast.
- **D:** Incorrect: the communist principle is itself an egalitarian ideal on a different metric, so equality is reinterpreted rather than discarded.

Examiner trap 11: Quoting the ability-and-need formula as an immediate wage rule ignores its explicit indexing to a higher stage of social cooperation, and invites an easy refutation on incentives.

MCQ 12. Why Sen shifts the metric to capability

What is Sen's central reason for evaluating equality in terms of capabilities rather than resources?

- A. Resources cannot be measured accurately, whereas capabilities admit of an exact and final numerical list.
- B. Resources are unimportant to well-being, since what matters to a person is only her subjective satisfaction.
- C. The same bundle of resources yields different real freedoms because persons differ in how they convert them.
- D. Capabilities are distributed equally by nature, so an equal distribution of them requires no institutional action.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: Sen explicitly declines to fix a rigid final list, preferring public reasoning, so the claim of exactness is the reverse of his position.
- **B:** Incorrect: capability is distinguished from utility as sharply as from income; the argument is not subjectivist.
- **C:** Correct: disability, age, gender, climate, health and social position change the conversion rate from resources into functioning, so equal holdings do not yield equal real freedom.
- **D:** Incorrect: the argument is that conversion differences require institutional attention, not that capabilities arrive equally distributed.

Examiner trap 12: Explaining Sen only as welfare economics loses the philosophical content; in this paper the marks are in *nīti* and *nyāya*, comparative justice, capability and public reasoning.

MCQ 13. Dworkin's luck distinction

Dworkin defends equality of resources rather than equality of welfare. Which distinction carries that position?

- A. Brute luck, which a person did not choose, against option luck, which is the outcome of a chosen risk.
- B. Natural talent, which is inherited, against acquired skill, which is developed by deliberate personal effort.
- C. Absolute deprivation, which is measurable, against relative deprivation, which is comparative and subjective.
- D. Primary goods, which institutions distribute, against secondary goods, which markets distribute privately.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: society may insure against unchosen misfortune without compensating every outcome of a voluntarily accepted risk, which is how equal concern coexists with responsibility.
- **B:** Incorrect: the talent/skill contrast is not the operative distinction, and the inheritance of talent is a Rawlsian rather than a Dworkinian pivot here.
- **C:** Incorrect: the absolute/relative deprivation contrast belongs to a different debate about measurement.
- **D:** Incorrect: primary goods are Rawls's metric, and the primary/secondary division stated here is not a Dworkinian device.

Examiner trap 13: Merging Dworkin's equality of resources with Sen's capability metric erases the conversion problem, which is exactly the point on which the two rivals divide.

MCQ 14. Berlin's actual claim about positive liberty

Which statement reports Berlin's position on positive liberty accurately?

- A. Positive liberty is incoherent, because a person cannot intelligibly be said to be governed by her own better self.
- B. Positive liberty is genuinely attractive, but its real-self doctrine can license coercion presented as emancipation.
- C. Positive liberty is the only defensible concept, since negative liberty ignores poverty, illiteracy and dependency.
- D. Positive liberty and negative liberty are the same concept described in two different philosophical vocabularies.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: Berlin does not deny the human appeal of self-mastery; his target is a political inference, not the concept's coherence.
- **B:** Correct: the warning is that when rulers claim to know a person's true interests better than she does, coercion can masquerade as liberation.
- **C:** Incorrect: that is the standard objection to Berlin, and his distinction need not deny social preconditions of freedom.
- **D:** Incorrect: the two concepts answer different questions - the size of the unobstructed area, and who is directing the self.

Examiner trap 14: Writing that Berlin "supports negative liberty and rejects positive liberty" flattens a warning about misuse into a preference, and it makes his concession about incapacity unintelligible.

MCQ 15. The mechanism that makes positive liberty politically dangerous

On Berlin's diagnosis, which step converts an ideal of self-mastery into a licence for coercion?

- A. The claim that human goods are many and cannot always be harmonised into a single ordering.
- B. The claim that education, health and security are preconditions of any effective exercise of freedom.
- C. The split between a "real self" and an "empirical self", after which a ruler may claim to speak for the first.
- D. The claim that law is a subtraction from liberty which must be justified as the lesser of two evils.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: value pluralism is Berlin's own background commitment and part of his defence, not the dangerous step.
- **B:** Incorrect: enabling conditions are expressly distinguished from a doctrine authorising forced perfection.
- **C:** Correct: once the person is divided, no independent check remains on who speaks for the real self, and coercion of the empirical self can be redescribed as liberation.
- **D:** Incorrect: that is a feature of the negative conception's view of law, not the mechanism internal to positive liberty.

Examiner trap 15: Treating the two concepts as more and less of one quantity hides the fact that a person can rate high on one and low on the other, which is what makes the distinction useful.

MCQ 16. What the harm principle rules out

According to Mill's harm principle, which of the following is *not* by itself a sufficient ground for coercing a competent adult?

- A. Preventing a clearly identified injury that the agent's conduct will inflict upon other persons.
- B. Enforcing a contract the agent voluntarily entered into with another party who now relies on it.
- C. Preventing conduct that would directly endanger the physical safety of identifiable third parties.
- D. The fact that a majority finds the agent's opinion or conduct offensive, mistaken or morally distasteful.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: prevention of harm to others is precisely the ground the principle authorises.
- **B:** Incorrect: enforcing voluntary undertakings concerns effects on other parties and falls outside the protected self-regarding sphere.
- **C:** Incorrect: endangering identifiable third parties is a paradigm of other-regarding conduct.
- **D:** Correct: offence or disapproval is not harm, and heterodox opinion may not be suppressed merely because the majority finds it false or offensive.

Examiner trap 16: Treating offence as a species of harm in order to make the principle workable collapses the very distinction on which Mill's argument rests.

MCQ 17. Four thinkers, four enemies of freedom

Hobbes, Locke, Rousseau and Green specify liberty differently. Which set of pairings identifies what each treats as freedom's principal enemy?

- A. Hobbes: incapacity · Locke: disorder · Rousseau: arbitrary power · Green: dependence on another's will.
- B. Hobbes: arbitrary power · Locke: incapacity · Rousseau: disorder · Green: dependence on another's will.
- C. Hobbes: dependence on another's will · Locke: incapacity · Rousseau: disorder · Green: arbitrary power.
- D. Hobbes: disorder · Locke: arbitrary power · Rousseau: dependence on another's will · Green: incapacity.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: it assigns Green's enemy to Hobbes and Hobbes's to Locke, inverting the whole sequence.
- **B:** Incorrect: Locke's constitutionalism is directed against arbitrary power, not against incapacity, which is Green's target.
- **C:** Incorrect: dependence on another's private will is answered by Rousseau's self-legislation, not by Hobbes's sovereign.
- **D:** Correct: security against disorder, known law against arbitrary power, self-legislation against dependence, and enabling conditions against incapacity.

Examiner trap 17: Reading Locke's "freedom under law" as a restriction of freedom misses that known law is, for him, the instrument that prevents the actual enemy - arbitrary power.

MCQ 18. Green's positive freedom in its defensible form

Which formulation states Green's position in the form that survives the paternalism objection?

- A. Institutions should enlarge a person's effective capacity for worthwhile action, leaving the choice of ends with her.
- B. Institutions should identify the ends worth pursuing and require citizens to adopt them for their own good.
- C. Institutions should remove all legal obstacles and then withdraw, since further action necessarily coerces.
- D. Institutions should equalise outcomes directly, since freedom is meaningless without material equality.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: the enabling reading enlarges capacity while leaving the choice with the agent, which is why education is the safest illustration.
- **B:** Incorrect: that is the perfectionist reading, and it is precisely what attracts Berlin's objection.
- **C:** Incorrect: this is the negative conception, which Green is arguing against.
- **D:** Incorrect: direct outcome equalisation is a distributive claim, not Green's account of what liberty is.

Examiner trap 18: Defending positive liberty without distinguishing enabling from perfectionist versions hands the objection its easiest target.

MCQ 19. The threshold in the liberty-equality relation

Which statement expresses the relation between liberty and equality in the form that earns the degree-judgement marks?

- A. Liberty and equality are permanently opposed, so every gain in one is exactly a loss in the other.
- B. They reinforce each other at the level of basic liberties and equal civic standing, and compete only beyond that threshold.
- C. They never conflict, because every measure that promotes one necessarily promotes the other as well.
- D. Their relation is indeterminate, so no general statement about conflict or harmony can responsibly be made.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: freedom of speech for all is simultaneously a liberty and an equality of civic standing, which refutes permanent opposition at the base.
- **B:** Correct: this locates the conflict rather than asserting or denying it, which is what "how far" and "does liberty limit equality" stems demand.
- **C:** Incorrect: unrestricted contract and property accumulation, and aggressive equalisation, both generate real conflict beyond the threshold.
- **D:** Incorrect: refusing to commit forfeits the degree judgement that the directive requires.

Examiner trap 19: Deploying the trade-off as though it operated at every level ignores that a *basic* liberty is by definition held equally by all, so securing it is itself an act of equalisation.

MCQ 20. Liberty in a technological society

Which verdict on the realisability of liberty in modern technological society is best supported?

- A. Liberty has been abolished, since surveillance and algorithmic steering leave no space for autonomous choice.
- B. Liberty is unaffected, since technology adds options and no formal option has been removed from anyone.
- C. Liberty remains realisable, but the threat has migrated from law that forbids to architecture that steers.
- D. Liberty is a pre-technological concept and should be replaced by an account of efficient system design.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: this is not a graded verdict, and an "explain" directive is not answered by an apocalyptic assertion.
- **B:** Incorrect: counting formal options is exactly the test that behavioural steering evades, since it changes which option is taken without removing any.
- **C:** Correct: coercion may now be infrastructural and informational, which is why transparency, accountability and zones of non-domination become liberty demands.
- **D:** Incorrect: replacing the normative question with a design question abandons the stem rather than answering it.

Examiner trap 20: Filling the 2020 answer with a list of technologies, or with invented incidents and statistics, replaces a conceptual degree question with unverifiable reportage.

MCQ 21. Interference and domination

On the republican account, which statement is correct about the relation between interference and domination?

- A. Every act of interference constitutes domination, which is why law always reduces the freedom of those subject to it.
- B. Domination occurs only where interference has actually taken place and can be identified by an observer.
- C. Interference is an act, while domination is a standing capacity to interfere arbitrarily; the two can come apart.
- D. Domination and interference are two names for the same phenomenon described from different points of view.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: that is the negative conception's view of law; on the republican account non-arbitrary law can interfere without dominating.
- **B:** Incorrect: the central case is the kind master who dominates precisely without interfering, because he retains the capacity to do so.
- **C:** Correct: the act/standing distinction is what allows interference without domination and domination without interference.
- **D:** Incorrect: identifying them would remove the very case that motivates the third family of liberty.

Examiner trap 21: Presenting non-domination as a version of positive liberty misplaces it; it is a third family, and Berlin's pair does not contain it.

MCQ 22. The republican consequence for law

What follows, on the republican view, about the relation between law and liberty?

- A. Law is always a subtraction from liberty and can be justified only as a lesser evil in the circumstances.
- B. Law is irrelevant to liberty, which is settled entirely by the distribution of material resources in society.
- C. Law reduces liberty in the private sphere while increasing it in the political sphere, with no net effect.
- D. Non-arbitrary law is freedom-constituting, because it strips private persons of arbitrary power over others.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: this is the negative conception's consequence, and the contrast between the two views is the point of the section.
- **B:** Incorrect: institutional form is central to the republican account, which demands contestability, publicity, review and interest-tracking.
- **C:** Incorrect: no such sphere-by-sphere netting appears in the argument.
- **D:** Correct: law that tracks the avowable interests of the governed and remains open to effective contestation removes private arbitrary power and therefore constitutes freedom.

Examiner trap 22: Merging Pettit and Skinner into a single citation loses an easy attribution mark: Pettit (**1997**) supplies the normative theory, Skinner (**1998**) the historical recovery.

MCQ 23. Formal, procedural and substantive justice

Which statement distinguishes the three forms of justice correctly?

- A. Formal justice evaluates outcomes, procedural justice evaluates rules, and substantive justice evaluates consistency of application.
- B. Formal justice concerns consistent application, procedural justice the fairness of the deciding process, and substantive justice the standard itself.
- C. Formal and procedural justice are identical, and substantive justice adds only a preference about the desired distribution.
- D. Procedural justice concerns consistency, formal justice concerns outcomes, and substantive justice concerns the hearing given to parties.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: it redistributes all three functions, assigning outcome-evaluation to the form that evaluates application.
- **B:** Correct: application, process and standard are three distinct objects of evaluation, which is why an unjust principle can be applied with perfect consistency.
- **C:** Incorrect: an unjust principle applied consistently satisfies formal justice while failing procedural or substantive tests, so the two are not identical.
- **D:** Incorrect: hearing and publicity are procedural requirements, not substantive ones.

Examiner trap 23: Collapsing justice into legality or into fair procedure ignores that a law may be valid yet unjust, and that procedural regularity can coexist with substantive injustice.

MCQ 24. Aristotle's two equalities

Which pairing of Aristotle's two justices with their corresponding equalities is correct?

- A. Distributive justice embodies proportional equality; corrective justice embodies arithmetic equality.
- B. Distributive justice embodies arithmetic equality; corrective justice embodies proportional equality.
- C. Both distributive and corrective justice embody proportional equality, differing only in their scope.
- D. Both distributive and corrective justice embody arithmetic equality, differing only in their subject matter.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: shares track a relevant criterion in distribution, while correction restores an arithmetic balance without regard to the parties' merit.
- **B:** Incorrect: it inverts the pair, and the inversion makes compensation depend on the recipient's desert.
- **C:** Incorrect: correction deliberately ignores the parties' qualities, which is why it cannot be proportional.
- **D:** Incorrect: distribution by relevant desert is precisely not an equal-units operation.

Examiner trap 24: Merging the two justices into "Aristotle's theory of justice" surrenders the technical vocabulary that makes the answer identifiably philosophical.

MCQ 25. Remedial - Merit and desert

Candidates routinely treat merit and desert as one idea. Which statement separates them correctly?

- A. Desert is functional and forward-looking; merit is moralised and backward-looking, tracking effort and sacrifice.
- B. Desert is backward-looking and moralised; merit is forward-looking and functional, tracking competence for a role.
- C. Desert applies only to material goods, while merit applies only to honours, prizes and public recognition.
- D. Desert and merit differ only in usage, since both name the same entitlement generated by past achievement.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: it swaps the two definitions exactly, which is the error the drill targets.
- **B:** Correct: a candidate may have great desert and little merit, or great merit and no desert, which is why the distinction does real work.
- **C:** Incorrect: both criteria can bear on either kind of good; the difference is temporal and evaluative, not a division of subject matter.
- **D:** Incorrect: collapsing them produces the standard bad answer that "merit is a moral entitlement".

Examiner trap 25: Defending selection by measured merit as a moral entitlement conceals that measured merit encodes prior access to nutrition, language, coaching and networks.

MCQ 26. Remedial - The compensatory principle and its limits

Which statement gives the compensatory principle together with the concession an examiner expects?

- A. Compensation is owed indefinitely, since historical injustice can never be fully measured or repaired.
- B. Compensation is unjustified, because present individuals who committed no wrong would bear its cost.
- C. Compensation is demanded by equality where disadvantage is transmitted, and it lapses when that transmission ceases.
- D. Compensation is a policy question with no philosophical content, so a philosophy answer should not discuss it.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: an indefinite remedy abandons the terminus that the principle itself supplies.
- **B:** Incorrect: the reply on record is that present individuals are not alleged to be guilty but to be unjustly advantaged by a continuing distribution.
- **C:** Correct: the principle is generalised corrective justice, and it lapses when the transmitted disadvantage it targets no longer operates; over-inclusion remains a genuine residual difficulty.
- **D:** Incorrect: the general compensatory principle is owned here as a criterion of distribution, even though the policy debate is routed to the caste owner.

Examiner trap 26: Expanding the compensatory principle into a reservation-policy essay imports the caste owner's material and leaves the criterion itself undefended.

MCQ 27. Remedial - The order of Rawls's principles

Which statement reproduces Rawls's ordering correctly?

- A. The difference principle is prior to fair equality of opportunity, which is in turn prior to equal basic liberties.
- B. Fair equality of opportunity is lexically prior to equal basic liberties, with the difference principle applied last.
- C. All three requirements apply simultaneously, and any of them may be traded against the others as needed.
- D. Equal basic liberties are lexically prior; within the second principle, fair equality of opportunity precedes the difference principle.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: it exactly reverses the order and would permit basic liberties to be traded for distributive gains.
- **B:** Incorrect: opportunity is part of the second principle and cannot outrank the first.
- **C:** Incorrect: simultaneity abolishes the priority rules, which are the device protecting liberty from aggregation.
- **D:** Correct: liberty first, then fair equality of opportunity, then the difference principle - and the ordering is itself examinable.

Examiner trap 27: Writing Rawls as though equality were his first principle is the single commonest error on this clause; the first principle secures equal basic liberties.

MCQ 28. Remedial - The status of the original position

How should the original position be described?

- A. A device of representation that models a fair choice situation, not a historical or actual contract.
- B. A historical agreement that founded modern constitutional states and can be dated from surviving records.
- C. A psychological description of how citizens actually deliberate about principles in a democratic society.
- D. A legal procedure by which a constitutional court decides between competing distributive principles.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: the abstraction is methodological, filtering morally arbitrary facts, and Rawls is explicit that no actual contract is asserted.
- **B:** Incorrect: no historical claim is made, and treating the device as history invites an irrelevant empirical refutation.
- **C:** Incorrect: it is a normative construction, not a report of deliberative psychology.
- **D:** Incorrect: it is not an institutional procedure, and no court applies it.

Examiner trap 28: Attacking the original position as historically false answers a claim Rawls never made, and it wastes the space that the unencumbered-self objection deserves.

MCQ 29. Remedial - Nozick, patterns and rectification

Which statement about Nozick's theory is correct?

- A. He defends a patterned principle of justice in which holdings must match a distribution proportioned to need.
- B. He rejects rectification, holding that past injustice is irrelevant once holdings have changed hands voluntarily.
- C. He accepts patterned principles for political rights while rejecting them for the distribution of material goods.
- D. He rejects patterned principles and defends a historical theory whose third component is justice in rectification.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: he explicitly opposes patterned principles, and need-proportioning is among his named targets.
- **B:** Incorrect: rectification is the third component of the entitlement theory; the criticism is that he under-specifies it, not that he omits it.
- **C:** Incorrect: no such split between political and material spheres appears in the entitlement theory.
- **D:** Correct: acquisition, transfer and rectification form the historical account, and the Wilt Chamberlain argument shows that voluntary transfer dissolves any fixed pattern.

Examiner trap 29: Presenting the Wilt Chamberlain case as an argument that inequality is good mistakes its function; it is an argument that voluntary transfer dissolves patterns, and self-ownership does the normative work.

MCQ 30. Remedial - Nīti and nyāya

Which rendering of Sen's pair is accurate?

- A. Nīti is realised justice in people's lives, while nyāya is the correctness of rules and institutions.
- B. Nīti is the correctness of institutions, rules and procedures; nyāya is justice as realised in social life.
- C. Nīti and nyāya both name institutional correctness, differing only in the tradition that uses each term.
- D. Nīti is distributive justice and nyāya is corrective justice, corresponding to Aristotle's two categories.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: it reverses the pair, and the reversal destroys the argument that fine rules can coexist with grave injustice.
- **B:** Correct: the contrast is what licenses the move from ideal institutional design to comparative assessment of how people actually fare.
- **C:** Incorrect: identifying the two removes the distinction the argument depends on.
- **D:** Incorrect: no mapping onto Aristotle's distributive and corrective justice is asserted, and the transposition is anachronistic.

Examiner trap 30: Using either term without an English gloss violates the English-first rule and leaves an examiner unable to credit the concept behind the word.

MCQ 31. Remedial - Attribution and dating

Which set of attributions is correct throughout?

- A. Pettit supplies the historical recovery of republicanism; Skinner supplies the normative theory of non-domination.
- B. Berlin introduces non-domination as a third concept of liberty alongside the negative and positive concepts.
- C. Pettit (1997) supplies the normative theory; Skinner (1998) the historical recovery; Mill's *On Liberty* is 1859 and *The Subjection of Women* 1869.
- D. Rawls (1974) states the difference principle, and Nozick (1971) replies with the entitlement theory of holdings.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the two roles are reversed; keeping them separate is an explicit requirement of this owner.
- **B:** Incorrect: non-domination is a third family developed after Berlin, and it must never be attributed to him.
- **C:** Correct: theory and history are separated, and Mill's two works are correctly dated nine years apart.
- **D:** Incorrect: the years are swapped - Rawls is **1971** and Nozick **1974**, and reversing them also reverses the direction of the reply.

Examiner trap 31: Inventing page numbers, chapters, editions or quotations for Pettit, Skinner, Rawls or Nozick converts a defensible citation into a fabrication that a specialist examiner will notice.

MCQ 32. Remedial - What this clause does not own

Which item should be routed away from an answer on social and political ideals?

- A. The competing justifications of reservation policy, the reverse-discrimination objection and the Indian judicial record.
- B. The distinction between formal, procedural and substantive justice as applied to a distribution of offices.
- C. The claim that political equality without social equality is unstable, used as a normative anchor.
- D. The contrast between equity and equality as it bears on distribution according to need and condition.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: this owner develops only the general compensatory principle; the affirmative-action debate and the Indian caste record belong to the caste owner.
- **B:** Incorrect: the three forms of justice are owned here and are required for composite justice stems.
- **C:** Incorrect: Ambedkar functions here as the normative foil for the instability of merely political equality.
- **D:** Incorrect: the equity/equality contrast is directly owned, and a previous-year part turns on it.

Examiner trap 32: Importing another owner's material - democratic institutional forms, Marxism as an ideology, or reservation policy - produces an off-target script that can read well and still score poorly.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

Practice status and source discipline - read once, applies to every solution below

Every model answer here is independent learner practice and is **never** an official UPSC key; UPSC publishes no descriptive model answer for Philosophy Paper II. Question wording is reproduced exactly as printed in the official papers, including the spacing before question marks that the repository's verified ledger records for the 2018, 2021 and 2024 parts, and the printed spelling "Rawl's" in the 2021 twenty-marker. The 2018 to 2025 Paper II texts are held locally, and the English wording of every part below follows the repository's verified Socio-Political PYQ ledger. Provenance is treated as examinable: **Rawls 1971, Nozick 1974, Berlin 1958, Mill 1859** for *On Liberty* and **1869** for *The Subjection of Women*, **Pettit 1997** for the normative theory of non-domination and **Skinner 1998** for its historical recovery. Marx's need-based formula is cited to the *Critique of the Gotha Programme* and Sen's distinction to *The Idea of Justice*, in both cases without page, chapter or edition detail and without invented quotation. Interpretive disputes - whether justice can order the other two ideals without already presupposing them, whether "arbitrary" can be specified non-circularly, whether comparative justice can choose between rival improvements, and whether the compensatory principle has a storable terminus - are flagged as contested rather than settled.

Answer-length convention used throughout this package. UPSC Philosophy Paper II parts are written longer than General Studies answers. The working bands used here are **10 marks - about 150 to 220 words, 15 marks - about 250 to 330 words, and 20 marks - about 330 to 400 words**. Every solution below sits inside its declared band, and the demand decoding, the verdict heading and the "why this earns marks" notes are teaching apparatus that sit **outside** the timed word count.

Coverage. ANALYSIS: Corpus signal: this clause owns **14 of 112** Socio-Political question-parts in the 2018-2025 corpus - the largest single share in the paper - distributed **2018: 1, 2019: 2, 2020: 1, 2021: 3, 2022: 2, 2023: 1, 2024: 2, 2025: 2**. All fourteen are solved in full below, followed by **six original solved Mains models**, two each at 10, 15 and 20 marks. The internal distribution is worth knowing before the exam: **equality** carries four parts (2021 Q1(b), 2022 Q2(c), 2025 Q1(e), and jointly 2024 Q2(b)), **liberty** four (2019 Q4(b), 2020 Q1(a), 2022 Q1(d), 2024 Q2(b)), **justice** five (2019 Q1(a), 2021 Q1(a), 2021 Q2(a), 2023 Q1(a), 2024 Q1(a)), and two composite parts (2018 Q2(a), 2025 Q4(a)) require all three. **ANALYSIS: Ownership discipline:** democracy-form questions owned by **Forms of Government** and Marxism-as-ideology questions owned by **Political Ideologies** are not counted here, and the 2022 Q2(c) part is routed to this owner because the demanded concept is equity against equality, with Marx supplying only the frame.

Solved PYQ 1 · 2018 · Q2(a) · 20 marks

Question: How far can liberty and equality be considered as distinctive features of democracy ? Discuss.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	"How far" plus "discuss" - a degree judgement is compulsory, not a yes or no
Core issue	Whether liberty and equality are <i>distinctive</i> of democracy, and whether they are <i>sufficient</i> for it
Scope boundary	Twenty marks: both ideals, their relation, one supplement, one graded verdict - not a survey of democratic institutions
Ideal thesis	They are distinctive but not exhaustive; each is indeterminate until justice and fraternity fix which liberties and which equalities matter
Non-negotiables	Political and social equality distinguished; the threshold of complementarity; Ambedkar's supplement; the ownership fence around forms of government

Independent model answer

Thesis. ANALYSIS: Liberty and equality are **distinctive but not exhaustive** features of democracy: they constitute its normative core, yet each is indeterminate until justice supplies an ordering criterion and fraternity sustains it. "How far" therefore demands a degree judgement.

What "distinctive" must mean. ANALYSIS: A feature is distinctive of democracy if it is constitutive of that regime type rather than merely compatible with it. Monarchies and oligarchies can grant liberties as concessions and can equalise some burdens administratively; what they cannot do is derive their authority from the equal standing of the ruled. That is the test applied below.

Liberty as a democratic feature. FACT: Democracy institutionalises negative liberties - speech, association, dissent - and also a positive, self-ruling liberty: on Rousseau's account the citizen obeys a law he helps to author, so obedience and freedom cease to be opposites. **ANALYSIS:** Without protected liberty, elections become ratification rather than choice, because the alternatives that make choosing meaningful cannot be formulated, published or organised.

Equality as a democratic feature. FACT: Political equality - equal vote and equal eligibility for office - and social equality, understood as the absence of status hierarchy and stigma, together give democracy its non-oligarchic standing. **FACT:** One person, one vote is itself an equality of civic worth rather than a mere counting rule, since it declares that no citizen's judgement is presumptively worth more than another's.

Their relation - the mark-bearing move. ANALYSIS: At the level of **basic liberties** the two reinforce one another, since freedom of speech *for all* is simultaneously a liberty and an equality of standing. They compete only beyond that threshold, where market liberty breeds inequality or aggressive equalisation curbs choice. **FACT:** Rawls's **lexical priority** of equal basic liberties (**1971**) shows that liberty need not be traded for aggregate welfare, and it converts the relation from a slogan into an institutional ordering.

The limit. FACT: Neither ideal by itself prevents majority tyranny, manipulated opinion, or the hollowing of political equality by social hierarchy. **ANALYSIS:** On the republican reading, formal political equality can coexist with dependence, since a voter who lives at another's discretion is dominated whether or not she is interfered with. **FACT:** Ambedkar's warning is decisive: political democracy is unstable without **social democracy** resting on liberty, equality and fraternity.

Verdict. ANALYSIS: Liberty and equality are genuinely distinctive of democracy - no other regime type makes both constitutive of its authority - but they are **necessary rather than sufficient**, and their scope is fixed only when justice orders them.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus: the stem contains a hidden second question. "Distinctive" is about what marks democracy off; "how far" is about sufficiency. Answer both, in that order.

Exam-length execution - 20 marks, about 330 to 400 words: thesis two lines; the meaning of "distinctive" three; liberty three; equality three; relation four; limit four; verdict two.

- **Structure:** thesis -> what "distinctive" requires -> liberty -> equality -> threshold relation -> limit -> graded verdict.
- **Doctrine:** negative and positive liberty; political and social equality; lexical priority.
- **Evidence:** Rousseau's self-authored law; free speech as liberty *and* equality; Rawls (1971); Ambedkar's social democracy.
- **Distinction:** distinctive against sufficient; complementarity at the base against rivalry beyond the threshold.
- **Criticism:** majority tyranny and social hierarchy as the limits neither ideal removes on its own.

Solved PYQ 2 · 2019 · Q1(a) · 10 marks

Question: How far do you think John Rawls is continuing with Plato's concept of justice?

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	"How far do you think" - a degree judgement with a named axis of comparison
Core issue	What exactly could be continuous between an ancient theory of right-order and a modern contractarian theory
Scope boundary	Ten marks: one continuity, two breaks, one verdict - not an exposition of either theory
Ideal thesis	Rawls inherits Plato's <i>question</i> , not his answer
Non-negotiables	Name the axis before judging; functional harmony against fair terms of cooperation; method and citizenship as the breaks

Independent model answer

Thesis. ANALYSIS: Rawls continues Plato only in a broad architectonic sense - justice as the virtue that structures a well-ordered whole - and breaks with him radically on method, citizenship and equality. The axis of comparison must be stated before the judgement.

The continuity. FACT: For Plato, justice is right-order: each part of soul and city performs its own proper function without usurping another's. For Rawls, justice is the first virtue of the **basic structure** - the fair terms of cooperation among free and equal persons. Both make justice the *ordering* virtue of the social whole rather than one desirable quality among others.

Break one - method. FACT: Plato reaches justice through functional differentiation and a metaphysical account of the good; Rawls reaches it through a hypothetical device, the **original position** under a **veil of ignorance**, which he expressly calls a device of representation rather than a cosmology or a historical contract.

Break two - equality and citizenship. FACT: Plato's order is a fixed hierarchy of natural kinds, in which justice consists partly in not aspiring beyond one's class. Rawls builds in equal basic liberties and fair equality of opportunity for equal citizens, and rejects caste-like closure outright.

Verdict. ANALYSIS: The continuity is thin and formal; the discontinuity is deep and substantive. Rawls inherits Plato's **question** - what makes a social whole well-ordered - and rejects his **answer**.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus: "how far" questions are lost by writing two summaries and adding "thus both are similar in some ways". Name the axis, then grade the continuity.

Exam-length execution - 10 marks, about 150 to 220 words: thesis two lines; continuity three; each break two; verdict two.

- **Structure:** axis named -> one continuity -> two breaks -> graded verdict.
- **Doctrine:** functional right-order; justice as the first virtue of the basic structure.
- **Evidence:** the three-class and three-part correspondence; the original position as a device of representation.
- **Distinction:** shared question against opposed answers.
- **Criticism:** implicit in the verdict, which refuses both "Rawls is a Platonist" and "there is no relation".

Solved PYQ 3 · 2019 · Q4(b) · 15 marks

Question: Does liberty put limitations to equality? Discuss.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	"Does... discuss" - a live tension must be exposed and then adjudicated
Core issue	Whether the limitation is general or holds only beyond a threshold
Scope boundary	Fifteen marks: one axis, both sides at full strength, one worked objection-reply, one conditional verdict
Ideal thesis	Liberty limits equality at the margin; at the level of basic liberties the two reinforce one another
Non-negotiables	The threshold; the republican reframing; a conditional rather than flat verdict

Independent model answer

Thesis. ANALYSIS: Liberty limits equality **at the margin** and supports it at the base. The question is therefore not whether a limitation exists but where it begins, and the answer must be conditional.

Where liberty does limit equality. FACT: Unrestricted freedom of contract, property accumulation and market power allow the strong to dominate the weak and generate durable material inequality - the process Rousseau describes when convention converts natural difference into dependence. FACT: Strong protection of the private domain can also block redistributive measures, so the limitation is real and not merely rhetorical.

Where it does not. FACT: Equal basic liberties **are** a form of equality: securing free speech, association and conscience for everyone is at once a liberty and an equality of civic standing. FACT: Rawls's priority rules (1971) permit inequality only under fair equality of opportunity and benefit to the least advantaged, so liberty on his account is not a licence to entrench privilege.

The reframing that carries the depth marks. ANALYSIS: On the republican view (Pettit, 1997; historical recovery, Skinner, 1998), material dependence is itself a form of **domination**: the un-interfered-with dependant is unfree precisely as a dependant. Certain equalising measures therefore *increase* freedom rather than trading against it, which shows that "liberty against equality" is not a zero-sum law but an artefact of one conception of liberty.

Objection and reply. CAUTION: It may be objected that any redistribution violates liberty by taking what persons were free to hold. ANALYSIS: The reply is that this assumes only state action can reduce freedom; where deprivation places persons under another's arbitrary power, redistribution protects freedom instead of negating it. The residual difficulty is that "arbitrary" remains partly indeterminate.

Verdict. ANALYSIS: Liberty limits equality where market advantage expands unchecked, and ceases to limit it at the level of basic liberties and equal standing - so the limitation is **conception-relative and threshold-bound**, not general.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus: the examiner is testing whether you can locate a threshold. A script that argues only one side has not discussed anything.

Exam-length execution - 15 marks, about 250 to 330 words: thesis two lines; limitation four; non-limitation four; reframing four; objection three; verdict two.

- **Structure:** thesis -> conflict case -> complementarity case -> republican reframing -> objection and reply -> conditional verdict.
- **Doctrine:** basic liberties; priority rules; non-domination.
- **Evidence:** Rousseau on convention; Rawls (1971); Pettit (1997) with Skinner (1998).
- **Distinction:** interference against domination; base against margin.
- **Criticism:** the indeterminacy of "arbitrary", conceded rather than hidden.

Solved PYQ 4 · 2020 · Q1(a) · 10 marks

Question: Is the concept of liberty realizable in the modern technological society? Explain.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	"Is... explain" - internal logic first; a graded answer, not a lament
Core issue	Whether technological society removes liberty or changes the form of the threat to it
Scope boundary	Ten marks: one ledger, one conceptual shift, one distinction, one conditional verdict
Ideal thesis	Liberty remains realisable, but coercion has migrated from law that forbids to architecture that steers
Non-negotiables	Convenience against autonomy; why an interference-count fails here; no invented incidents or statistics

Independent model answer

Thesis. ANALYSIS: Liberty remains realisable in technological society, but only under vigilance: the threat has migrated from **law that forbids** to **architecture that steers**.

The two-sided ledger. ANALYSIS: Technology expands knowledge, mobility, communication and choice, while enabling surveillance, manipulation of choice and the concentration of informational power.

The conceptual shift. ANALYSIS: Coercion today may be **infrastructural and informational** rather than legal. The classical test looked for a rule that prohibits; behavioural steering prohibits nothing. Algorithmic nudging can leave every formal option open while shaping which option is actually taken, so a purely negative test - counting removed options - registers no loss of freedom at all.

The controlling distinction. ANALYSIS: *Convenience is not autonomy*. A person may hold more choices and less control over the terms on which she chooses. ANALYSIS: Here the republican test earns its place: what matters is that another party holds an unaccountable capacity to set those terms.

Objection and reply. CAUTION: It may be said that modern complexity requires pervasive management. ANALYSIS: Even so, liberty demands transparency, accountability and zones insulated from arbitrary informational power; the argument concerns how such systems are governed, not whether they exist.

Verdict. ANALYSIS: Realisable, conditionally. CAUTION: How far any given society has already crossed the line is an empirical question this answer does not settle.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus: the fatal script here is a list of technologies. The stem is conceptual: what *kind* of unfreedom is at issue, and which test detects it.

Exam-length execution - 10 marks, about 150 to 220 words: thesis one line; ledger two; shift four; distinction three; objection two; verdict two.

- **Structure:** thesis -> ledger -> migration of coercion -> convenience against autonomy -> objection and reply -> conditional verdict.
- **Doctrine:** infrastructural coercion; non-domination as the detecting test.
- **Evidence:** algorithmic nudging as the standing example of preserved options and steered choice.
- **Distinction:** formal option against effective control of terms.
- **Criticism:** the complexity objection, answered by transparency and contestability rather than by abolition.

Solved PYQ 5 · 2021 · Q1(a) · 10 marks

Question: Discuss critically the distributive theory of justice as propounded by R. Nozick.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	"Discuss critically " - the objection and reply layer is the answer, not an appendix
Core issue	That Nozick's is an anti-distributive, historical theory, and where its historical premise fails
Scope boundary	Ten marks: three principles, the pattern contrast, one argument, one criticism, one verdict
Ideal thesis	The framework is coherent; its historical premise is unsatisfied and its own remedy under-specified
Non-negotiables	Acquisition, transfer, rectification; patterned against historical; Wilt Chamberlain reconstructed, not just named

Independent model answer

Thesis. ANALYSIS: Nozick's theory is **anti-distributive** in the usual sense: justice in holdings is settled by history, not by the shape of the final distribution. The framework is internally coherent; its historical premise is where it fails.

The three principles. FACT: Justice in **acquisition** governs how previously unowned things may justly be acquired; justice in **transfer** governs voluntary exchange, gift and transfer; justice in **rectification** governs the correction of past injustice.

Patterned against historical. FACT: A patterned principle asks whether the current distribution fits a preferred shape - equality, need or merit. A historical principle asks how each holding arose. **FACT:** In the **Wilt Chamberlain** argument, we begin from any distribution the reader accepts as just, allow many people to pay a small sum voluntarily to watch one performer, and find the pattern broken by voluntary acts alone. Either the new distribution is just, or liberty must be continuously restricted to preserve patterns.

The criticism. ANALYSIS: Actual acquisitions are rarely clean: conquest, exclusion, power asymmetry and coercive necessity undermine the voluntariness the theory requires. Nozick provides for rectification but leaves it substantially **under-specified**, so the principle that would repair the defect is the least developed part of the theory.

Verdict. ANALYSIS: A powerful warning against overreaching redistribution, and a defective account of real societies whose starting points were never innocent.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus: "critically" is satisfied by an internal criticism - one drawn from the theory's own third principle - not by an external assertion that inequality is bad.

Exam-length execution - 10 marks, about 150 to 220 words: thesis two lines; principles three; contrast and argument four; criticism three; verdict one.

- **Structure:** thesis -> three principles -> pattern contrast with the argument -> internal criticism -> verdict.
- **Doctrine:** entitlement theory; self-ownership as side-constraint.
- **Evidence:** the Wilt Chamberlain reconstruction; the minimal state's limits.
- **Distinction:** end-state shape against process.
- **Criticism:** the unclear historical premise and the under-specified rectification principle.

Solved PYQ 6 · 2021 · Q1(b) · 10 marks

Question: How does Rousseau distinguish between natural and artificial inequality ? Explain.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	"How does he distinguish... explain" - exposition of the contrast, not an evaluation of Rousseau
Core issue	The two categories, the mechanism of conversion, and what the distinction does not claim
Scope boundary	Ten marks: definitions, mechanism, one example, one limit - no state-of-nature narrative
Ideal thesis	The distinction is diagnostic: the oppressive forms are socially produced and socially maintained
Non-negotiables	Both categories named exactly; property and comparison as mechanisms; the command example

Independent model answer

Thesis. FACT: Rousseau separates **natural or physical inequality** from **moral or political inequality**, often called artificial, and argues that only the second is politically decisive.

The two categories. FACT: Natural inequality covers differences of age, bodily strength, health and intelligence - differences established by nature. FACT: Moral or political inequality covers wealth, honour, power, dependence and social superiority - differences established by **convention** and maintained by institutions.

The mechanism of conversion. FACT: Natural differences become politically toxic when institutions convert them into durable domination and vanity. Rousseau names two mechanisms: **property**, which fixes advantage in transferable form, and **social comparison**, which turns difference into rivalry and esteem-seeking. Civil society therefore deepens dependence rather than merely recording pre-existing difference.

The example that settles it. FACT: One person being stronger than another is natural. One person **commanding** another because convention sanctifies property and status is moral or political inequality.

What the distinction does not claim. FACT: Rousseau is not asserting that all inequality is conventional, nor that natural difference is politically irrelevant. The thesis is narrower and stronger: the most oppressive forms are socially produced and socially maintained - and therefore socially remediable.

Verdict. ANALYSIS: The distinction is **diagnostic, not pastoral**. Its force is that institutions magnify and then legitimise inequalities far beyond anything natural difference could support, which shifts the burden of justification onto hierarchy itself.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus: "explain" forbids importing criticism at the cost of exposition. The mechanism of conversion is the mark-bearing content.

Exam-length execution - 10 marks, about 150 to 220 words: thesis one line; categories three; mechanism four; example two; limit two; verdict two.

- **Structure:** thesis -> two categories -> conversion mechanism -> example -> limit -> diagnostic verdict.
- **Doctrine:** natural against moral or political inequality.
- **Evidence:** property and social comparison; the strength-against-command contrast.
- **Distinction:** difference established by nature against difference established by convention.
- **Criticism:** kept to the closing qualification, as an "explain" directive requires.

Solved PYQ 7 · 2021 · Q2(a) · 20 marks

Question: Discuss whether Amartya Sen's idea of justice is an improvement upon Rawl's theory of justice.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	"Is X an improvement upon Y" - the criterion of improvement must be named before the verdict
Core issue	Comparative against transcendental institutionalism; capability against primary goods
Scope boundary	Twenty marks: both positions at strength, two objection-reply chains, one criterion-relative verdict
Ideal thesis	Sen improves in reach and diagnosis; Rawls retains institutional determinacy - improvement is criterion-relative
Non-negotiables	Nīti and nyāya glossed in English; what Rawls still does better; the printed spelling "Rawl's" left unaltered in the question

Independent model answer

Thesis. ANALYSIS: "Improvement" is **criterion-relative**. Judged by reach into realised lives, Sen improves on Rawls; judged by institutional determinacy and the protection of basic liberties by rule, Rawls retains the advantage. The criterion must be stated before the verdict.

Rawls at full strength. FACT: Principles are chosen in the **original position** behind a **veil of ignorance**, yielding equal basic liberties with **lexical priority**, then fair equality of opportunity, then the **difference principle**. The construction answers the aggregation objection: no one may be sacrificed for a larger total, because no chooser can gamble on occupying someone else's position.

Sen's criticism. FACT: Sen distinguishes **nīti** - the correctness of institutions, rules and procedures - from **nyāya**, justice as actually realised in people's lives. A society may have fine rules on paper and produce grave injustice in practice. He therefore rejects **transcendental institutionalism**: we can identify manifest injustices and rank alternatives without first agreeing on a perfectly just basic structure.

The metric. FACT: Sen replaces primary goods with **capability** - what persons are actually able to do and to be - because disability, age, gender, climate, health and social position change how resources convert into functioning. Equal income does not yield equal mobility or voice.

First objection and reply. CAUTION: Comparative judgement without a benchmark may under-determine the choice between two rival improvements. **ANALYSIS:** Sen answers that public reasoning and manifest injustice supply enough orientation, and that demanding a complete ideal before acting is itself a source of paralysis.

Second objection and reply. CAUTION: Capability comparison is measurement-heavy and open-ended. **ANALYSIS:** Sen prefers reasoned public assessment to spurious exactness, deliberately declining a rigid final list - a defensible choice for plural societies that nonetheless costs determinacy.

What Rawls still does better. ANALYSIS: Institutions remain the indispensable precondition of any realised justice, and the lexical priority rule protects liberty by rule rather than by ongoing judgement.

Verdict. ANALYSIS: Sen improves on Rawls in diagnosis and reach and does not displace him in institutional design; the honest ruling is that the two are complementary, with priority decided by the criterion invoked.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus: the single commonest failure is asserting improvement without a standard. Name the standard in the first two lines.

Exam-length execution - 20 marks, about 330 to 400 words: thesis two lines; Rawls four; criticism four; metric three; each objection three; concession two; verdict two.

- **Structure:** criterion named -> Rawls at strength -> Sen's criticism -> metric -> two objection-reply chains -> concession -> criterion-relative verdict.
- **Doctrine:** original position; lexical priority; nīti and nyāya; capability.
- **Evidence:** the conversion argument; the paper-rules-and-practice contrast.

- **Distinction:** comparative against transcendental institutionalism.
- **Criticism:** under-determination and measurement openness, both conceded and answered.

Solved PYQ 8 · 2022 · Q1(d) · 10 marks

Question: "Complete liberty may lead to inequality while order and restrictions imply a necessary loss of freedom." Critically discuss.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	" Critically discuss " a quoted statement - take the claim apart limb by limb, then adjudicate
Core issue	The statement contains two claims, and only the first survives intact
Scope boundary	Ten marks: both limbs, one reframing, one graded verdict - not a general essay on freedom
Ideal thesis	The first limb is broadly right; the second smuggles in a contested conception of liberty
Non-negotiables	Treat the two limbs separately; use the republican reframing on the second; do not simply agree

Independent model answer

Thesis. ANALYSIS: The statement joins a **defensible** claim to a **question-begging** one. Complete liberty does tend to generate inequality; that order and restriction imply a *necessary* loss of freedom is true on one conception of liberty and false on another.

Limb one - complete liberty and inequality. FACT: Unrestricted freedom of contract, property accumulation and market power let the strong dominate the weak, and Rousseau supplies the mechanism: convention converts difference into durable dependence.

Limb two - the hidden premise. ANALYSIS: "A necessary loss of freedom" presupposes the **negative** conception, on which every law is *prima facie* a subtraction from liberty. ANALYSIS: On the republican conception (**Pettit, 1997**), law that tracks the avowable interests of the governed and remains publicly contestable **constitutes** freedom, because it strips private persons of arbitrary power. "Necessary" is doing illegitimate work.

The reframing. ANALYSIS: The limbs are therefore in tension: if unregulated liberty produces dependence, and dependence is unfreedom, well-designed restriction can *increase* aggregate freedom.

The concession. FACT: Not every restriction is of the right kind. Arbitrary or perfectionist regulation does subtract freedom, and Berlin's warning about coercion imposed for a citizen's "real self" remains apposite.

Verdict. ANALYSIS: Accept the first limb, reject the necessity in the second, and locate the truth in a **threshold**: restriction that removes arbitrary power constitutes freedom; restriction that substitutes official judgement for personal choice destroys it.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus: statement questions are lost by agreeing wholesale. Split the quotation, find the unargued premise, and rule on each limb separately.

Exam-length execution - 10 marks, about 150 to 220 words: thesis two lines; limb one two; limb two four; reframing two; concession two; verdict two.

- **Structure:** split the statement -> limb one accepted -> limb two's hidden premise exposed -> reframing -> concession -> threshold verdict.
- **Doctrine:** negative conception of law; republican freedom-constituting law.
- **Evidence:** Rousseau on convention; Pettit (1997); Berlin's real-self warning.
- **Distinction:** restriction that removes arbitrary power against restriction that replaces choice.
- **Criticism:** the concession that perfectionist regulation genuinely does subtract freedom.

Solved PYQ 9 · 2022 · Q2(c) · 15 marks

Question: Explain the difference between the notion of equity and equality with reference to Marxian philosophy.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	" Explain the difference" - exposition with a controlled contrast, not an evaluation of Marxism
Core issue	Equality as one common measure against equity as need-sensitive differentiation
Scope boundary	Fifteen marks: the contrast, the critique of formal equality, the formula, the stage-qualification
Ideal thesis	For Marx an equal right can be a right of inequality, so equity is the more demanding ideal
Non-negotiables	The Gotha formula; the two-stage indexing; ownership fence against the ideology owner

Independent model answer

Thesis. FACT: In the Marxian frame, **equality** names one common measure applied to all, while **equity** names differentiated treatment responsive to need and actual condition. The difference matters because a single measure applied to unequally placed persons produces unequal effect.

The critique of formal equality. FACT: Marx is suspicious of merely formal equality under capitalism because formally equal exchange can conceal material exploitation. The wage contract *appears* free and equal between legal equals, while class power shapes production and appropriation. Bourgeois equality therefore abstracts from class structure.

Why equal right can be a right of inequality. FACT: Equal right is measured by a common standard, but persons differ in need, burden, family condition and starting position. Applying the identical standard to them guarantees an unequal result - which is why the formal ideal, taken alone, ratifies rather than removes class domination.

The equity principle. FACT: The canonical formula from the *Critique of the Gotha Programme* is: "From each according to his ability, to each according to his need." **FACT:** Distribution by need is the distributive rule of the higher stage; unequal needs justify differentiated shares.

The illustration. ANALYSIS: Equal wages for equal hours may still be inequitable where one worker supports dependants and another does not - with the immediate qualification that Marx's deeper claim concerns the wage relation itself, which he holds to be structurally exploitative, not merely the scale of pay.

Objection and reply. CAUTION: Need-based distribution is vague and may weaken incentive. **ANALYSIS:** The reply is that the principle is indexed to a higher stage of social cooperation in which alienated labour and scarcity are transformed; it is not offered as a market-time salary rule, so the incentive objection misses its intended domain.

Verdict. ANALYSIS: Equity is the more demanding ideal because it evaluates shares against actual condition rather than against a single measure. **ANALYSIS:** The two-stage structure is nevertheless a normative projection, not a demonstrated historical law, and an accurate answer says so.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus: the demanded concept is the contrast. Marx supplies the frame; Marxism as an ideology belongs to another owner and must not colonise the script.

Exam-length execution - 15 marks, about 250 to 330 words: thesis two lines; critique three; the right-of-inequality argument three; formula two; illustration three; objection three; verdict two.

- **Structure:** contrast stated -> critique of formal equality -> why equal right can be a right of inequality -> the formula -> illustration -> objection and reply -> qualified verdict.
- **Doctrine:** formal equality; equity as need-sensitivity; the two-stage distributive structure.
- **Evidence:** the Gotha formula; the dependants illustration; the appearance of freedom in the wage contract.
- **Distinction:** same measure for all against treatment answering to actual condition.
- **Criticism:** vagueness and incentive, answered by the stage-indexing and then qualified as a projection.

Solved PYQ 10 · 2023 · Q1(a) · 10 marks

Question: What is meant by justice as fairness? Explain Rawls' theory of justice.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	Two-part stem: define the phrase, then expound the theory - both parts must appear
Core issue	Why fairness is built into the <i>choice situation</i> rather than asserted about outcomes
Scope boundary	Ten marks: device, two principles, the priority order, one qualification
Ideal thesis	Fairness is procedural at the point of selection, which is what makes the resulting principles binding
Non-negotiables	Original position; veil of ignorance; the ordering; device of representation

Independent model answer

Definition. FACT: "Justice as fairness" names Rawls's claim that principles of justice are those that would be chosen under conditions which are themselves fair. Fairness is built into the **selection procedure**, not asserted about an outcome.

The device. FACT: Parties choose principles for the **basic structure** of society in an **original position** behind a **veil of ignorance**, ignorant of their class, gender, race, natural talents, religion and conception of the good. FACT: Because no one can identify her own position, no one can tailor principles to personal fortune. FACT: This is a **device of representation**, not a historical contract.

The two principles. FACT: First, each person has an equal claim to a fully adequate scheme of **equal basic liberties**, compatible with the same scheme for all. FACT: Second, inequalities must attach to offices open under **fair equality of opportunity**, and must work to the greatest benefit of the **least advantaged** - the difference principle.

The priority order. FACT: The first principle is **lexically prior**: basic liberties may not be reduced for greater social or economic advantage. Within the second, fair equality of opportunity precedes the difference principle.

Justification and qualification. FACT: Principles are tested in **reflective equilibrium**, by mutual adjustment between principles and considered judgements. ANALYSIS: Rawls does not abolish inequality; he civilises it. CAUTION: The objection that the chooser is unencumbered is met by noting that the abstraction is methodological.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus: two-part stems are lost by answering only the second half. Define the phrase first, in one clean sentence.

Exam-length execution - 10 marks, about 150 to 220 words: definition two lines; device three; principles three; order two; justification and qualification three.

- **Structure:** definition -> device -> two principles -> priority order -> justification and qualification.
- **Doctrine:** justice as fairness; basic structure; reflective equilibrium.
- **Evidence:** the veil's information restriction; the lexical priority rule.
- **Distinction:** device of representation against historical contract.
- **Criticism:** the unencumbered-self objection, met by the methodological reading of abstraction.

Solved PYQ 11 · 2024 · Q1(a) · 10 marks

Question: Briefly discuss Plato's concept of justice.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	" Briefly discuss" - compression is part of the demand; one tension is still required
Core issue	Justice as right-order in soul and city, and the objection that it freezes hierarchy
Scope boundary	Ten marks: the correspondence, the definition, one objection with reply, one verdict
Ideal thesis	Justice is functional harmony, valuable as a norm of competence and vulnerable as a social order
Non-negotiables	The three-class and three-part correspondence; "each doing one's own work"; no modern distributive vocabulary

Independent model answer

Thesis. FACT: For Plato, justice is a principle of **order and harmony** in both soul and city: each part performs its own proper function without usurping another's role.

The correspondence. FACT: In the city, rulers rule, auxiliaries defend and producers provide. FACT: In the soul, reason governs, spirit supports and appetite obeys. Justice is the condition in which this ordering holds; injustice is the condition in which appetite rules reason, or a class intrudes into a function for which it is not suited.

What kind of concept this is. FACT: Justice here is not merely external distribution but **inner and civic right-order**. It presupposes natural functional differentiation in soul and polis, and treats justice as the virtue coordinating plurality into a harmonious whole rather than as a rule for allocating shares.

Objection. ANALYSIS: The standard criticism is that this subordinates individuality to a fixed hierarchy: justice comes to consist partly in not aspiring beyond one's class.

Reply. ANALYSIS: Defenders answer that the aim is not arbitrary privilege but a norm of **competence** and organic harmony - the claim is that functions should be discharged by those fitted for them.

Verdict. ANALYSIS: The idea survives the institution. "Competence should govern function" remains defensible; the further claim that classes are naturally fixed does not, and a modern reader may accept the first while rejecting the second.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus: "briefly" does not mean "without a tension". One objection and one reply are still required, compressed to two lines each.

Exam-length execution - 10 marks, about 150 to 220 words: thesis one line; correspondence three; conceptual character three; objection one; reply one; verdict two.

- **Structure:** definition -> correspondence -> what kind of concept -> objection -> reply -> verdict separating idea from institution.
- **Doctrine:** justice as each doing one's own work; functional differentiation.
- **Evidence:** rulers-auxiliaries-producers; reason-spirit-appetite.
- **Distinction:** right-order against distribution of shares.
- **Criticism:** the hierarchy objection, answered by the competence reading and then bounded.

Solved PYQ 12 · 2024 · Q2(b) · 15 marks

Question: Critically evaluate the concepts of liberty and equality as political ideals.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	" Critically evaluate " both concepts - each needs a strength, an objection, a reply and a residual problem
Core issue	The internal indeterminacy of each ideal, and the relation between them
Scope boundary	Fifteen marks: two evaluations plus the relation; justice enters as the ordering criterion, briefly
Ideal thesis	Both are indispensable and internally under-specified; their evaluation converges on the need for an ordering criterion
Non-negotiables	Berlin's pair; the metric question; the threshold; one residual problem each

Independent model answer

Thesis. ANALYSIS: Liberty and equality are indispensable political ideals whose weakness is identical in form: each is a **family of demands** rather than a single demand, and neither can rank its own members.

Liberty evaluated. FACT: Its strength is the protection of a sphere of action and thought, without which a person acts only by another's permission. FACT: Berlin's distinction shows the family's internal division: freedom **from** interference against freedom **to** be one's own master. ANALYSIS: The objection to the negative pole is that it ignores poverty, illiteracy and dependency; the objection to the positive pole is that the real-self doctrine licenses coercion presented as liberation. ANALYSIS: The reply is that enabling conditions such as education expand freedom without dictating a life-plan. CAUTION: The residual problem is that no agreed test separates enablement from prescription.

Equality evaluated. FACT: Its strength is the demand that persons be treated with equal concern, so arbitrary hierarchy must justify itself. FACT: But "equality of what?" divides the family - status, rights, opportunity, welfare, resources or capability. ANALYSIS: The objection that equality means levelling is met by the threshold reply: floors of decent capability and ceilings on avoidable deprivation, not identical holdings. CAUTION: The residual problem is that the threshold remains under-specified.

The relation. ANALYSIS: At the level of basic liberties and equal civic standing the two reinforce one another - free speech for all is at once a liberty and an equality. They compete beyond that threshold, where market advantage expands or equalisation reaches into choice.

Verdict. ANALYSIS: Both ideals survive criticism and neither survives alone. The evaluation of each converges on the same conclusion: an **ordering criterion** is required, and supplying it is the work of justice.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus: "critically evaluate" applied to two concepts means two complete evaluation cycles, not one long comparison.

Exam-length execution - 15 marks, about 250 to 330 words: thesis two lines; liberty six; equality six; relation three; verdict two.

- **Structure:** shared diagnosis -> liberty evaluated -> equality evaluated -> relation -> converging verdict.
- **Doctrine:** negative and positive liberty; the metric question; the threshold.
- **Evidence:** Berlin's pair; the capability floor; free speech as liberty and equality.
- **Distinction:** enablement against prescription; equal worth against identical holdings.
- **Criticism:** two residual problems stated explicitly rather than resolved by assertion.

Solved PYQ 13 · 2025 · Q1(e) · 10 marks

Question: Discuss the salient features of equality according to J.S. Mill.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	"Discuss the salient features " - an enumerated account with one live tension
Core issue	The six features, and the qualification that makes Mill a <i>qualified</i> egalitarian
Scope boundary	Ten marks: the features compressed, the gender argument developed, one objection
Ideal thesis	Equal status without uniformity: hierarchy is removed in order to release individuality
Non-negotiables	1859 and 1869 correctly assigned; the manufactured-nature argument; the limit on coercive equalisation

Independent model answer

Thesis. FACT: Mill is a liberal egalitarian **in a qualified sense**: he affirms equal moral standing, equal civic and legal status and the equality of women, while resisting levelling that would suppress individuality.

The salient features. FACT: (i) **Equal worth in moral accounting** - each person counts, and none is discounted for birth or station. FACT: (ii) **Equality before the law and equal citizenship** - privilege by status is indefensible. FACT: (iii) **Women's equality** - in *The Subjection of Women* (1869), the legal and social subordination of women is a relic of domination, not a dictate of nature. FACT: (iv) **Equality compatible with individuality** - the goal is free self-development, not sameness. FACT: (v) **Hostility to custom-made hierarchy** - inherited subordination blocks both utility and justice. ANALYSIS: (vi) **Qualified economic concern** - reform of property relations and labour conditions, but not extinction of all differences by coercive equalisation.

The argument that unifies them. FACT: A society that excludes half its members, or attaches rights to status, wastes human capacities and violates utility properly understood.

The gender argument, precisely. FACT: The appeal to women's "nature" is worthless as evidence, because that nature has been socially manufactured through subjection.

Objection and verdict. ANALYSIS: Mill remains too individualistic to reach structural economic inequality - a fair charge. ANALYSIS: Within liberalism, however, he carries equality beyond formal rights into social relations, and the verdict is **equal status without uniformity**.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus: a features question still needs a tension. Feature six and the objection supply it without disturbing the enumeration.

Exam-length execution - 10 marks, about 150 to 220 words: thesis one line; six features five; unifying argument two; gender argument one; objection and verdict three.

- **Structure:** qualified thesis -> six features -> unifying argument -> the gender argument -> objection and verdict.
- **Doctrine:** equal status; individuality; custom-made hierarchy.
- **Evidence:** *On Liberty* (1859) and *The Subjection of Women* (1869); the wasted-capacities argument.
- **Distinction:** equality of status and chance against uniformity of life plan.
- **Criticism:** the structural-economics charge, conceded and bounded.

Solved PYQ 14 · 2025 · Q4(a) · 20 marks

Question: How are both equality and liberty inadequate as social and political ideals without justice? Discuss.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	" How are they inadequate... discuss" - the mechanism of inadequacy is the answer
Core issue	That each ideal is indeterminate about its own variants, so an external ordering criterion is required
Scope boundary	Twenty marks: both inadequacies, the criteria justice supplies, a composite evaluation, one dated Indian illustration
Ideal thesis	The inadequacy is structural, not practical: a family of demands cannot rank its own members
Non-negotiables	The two under-specification arguments; the list of justice criteria; a graded verdict conceding the objection

Independent model answer

Thesis. ANALYSIS: The inadequacy is **structural, not practical**. Liberty and equality are each a *family* of demands, and no member of a family is privileged from inside it - so the ordering criterion must range over both, and that criterion is what justice names.

Liberty is under-specified. FACT: "Liberty" does not say **whose** liberty, **to do what**, **against whom**, or **with what effect on others**. Berlin's two concepts divide the family at once, and the republican account adds a third specification, freedom as a secured standing. Nothing internal to liberty ranks these.

Equality is under-specified. FACT: "Equality" does not say equality of status, rights, opportunity, welfare, resources, capabilities or outcome. Sen's capability metric, Dworkin's equality of resources and the threshold view are rivals within the family, and again nothing internal to equality adjudicates between them.

What justice supplies. FACT: Justice furnishes the competing adjudicatory criteria - **desert, fairness, entitlement, need, capability, rectification and public reason** - and the sphere-sensitivity that assigns each criterion to its proper good: equal share for political rights, competence for offices, need for subsistence, compensation for transmitted disadvantage.

Composite evaluation. ANALYSIS: A liberty-first position protects self-ownership and resists paternalism, but background injustice hollows out real freedom, so it is insightful and incomplete. An equality-first levelling position exposes structural oppression, but may flatten choice, desert and pluralism, so it is a necessary warning rather than a sufficient ideal. Justice as the ordering ideal balances both by principle.

The Indian anchor. FACT: Articles 14 to 16 of the Constitution of India establish equality before the law, prohibition of discrimination and equality of opportunity in public employment, with enabling clauses in Articles 15 and 16 permitting special provision for specified classes. **ANALYSIS:** An enabling clause is a **permission**, not a philosophical justification: the argument for using it must still be made on one of the criteria above. **FACT:** Ambedkar's warning completes the point - political democracy is unstable without social democracy resting on liberty, equality and fraternity.

Objection and verdict. CAUTION: It may be objected that theories of justice themselves disagree, so calling justice the ordering ideal merely relocates the problem. **ANALYSIS:** Relocation is progress: it converts a clash of ideals into an argument about criteria, which can be conducted with reasons and public scrutiny. **ANALYSIS:** The verdict is therefore that liberty and equality are indispensable and jointly insufficient, and that any defensible arrangement must make its ordering criterion explicit.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus: "how are they inadequate" asks for a mechanism. Two under-specification arguments, then the criteria justice supplies - in that order.

Exam-length execution - 20 marks, about 330 to 400 words: thesis two lines; liberty three; equality three; justice's criteria three; composite evaluation four; Indian anchor four; objection and verdict three.

- **Structure:** structural thesis -> liberty under-specified -> equality under-specified -> criteria supplied -> composite evaluation -> dated Indian illustration -> objection and graded verdict.
- **Doctrine:** indeterminacy of each ideal; sphere-sensitivity; social democracy.
- **Evidence:** Berlin's pair and the third family; Sen and Dworkin as rival metrics; Articles 14-16; Ambedkar.
- **Distinction:** constitutional permission against philosophical justification.
- **Criticism:** the relocation objection, answered without pretending the clash of criteria is settled.

Six original questions in the style of the paper - two each at 10, 15 and 20 marks - covering the parts of the clause that the 2018-2025 corpus has not yet examined directly: the three forms of justice, the criteria problem, republican non-domination, the compensatory principle, Berlin against Green, and the Mill-Marx comparison on the limits of formal equality. Every model answer is independent learner practice and is never an official key.

ORIGINAL MAINS PRACTICE WITH MODEL SOLUTIONS

Original 1 · 10 marks

Question: Distinguish formal, procedural and substantive justice, and explain why none of them is sufficient by itself.

Independent model answer

Thesis. FACT: The three name three different objects of evaluation - the **application** of a rule, the **process** that produces a decision, and the **standard** itself - and each fails alone because it is silent about what the other two evaluate.

Formal justice. FACT: It asks whether announced principles are applied impartially and consistently to like cases, and it demands generality and the absence of personal favour. ANALYSIS: Its failure is immediate: an unjust principle can be applied with perfect consistency, so consistency certifies nothing about the principle.

Procedural justice. FACT: It asks whether the decision was produced by fair rules, hearing, publicity, impartiality and non-cheating, and it demands a process that excludes arbitrary power. ANALYSIS: Its failure is subtler: a fair-looking procedure can operate on a grossly unequal background, converting inherited disadvantage into formally impeccable results.

Substantive justice. FACT: It asks whether the governing principle, the distribution and the social relations are themselves just, and it demands rights, fair life-chances and protection against deprivation and status subordination. ANALYSIS: Its failure is the mirror image: an outcome imposed without publicity, hearing and consistent limits becomes a second arbitrariness.

The conclusion. ANALYSIS: Justice therefore requires **fair procedure plus a defensible substantive criterion**, each disciplining the other. FACT: Equal legal punishment imposed for unequal wrongdoing illustrates the point exactly: it satisfies consistency and violates corrective fairness.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus: three definitions earn little; three definitions each with its own failure earn the question.

- **Structure:** thesis -> three forms, each with its failure -> conclusion -> illustration.
- **Doctrine:** application, process and standard as distinct objects of evaluation.
- **Evidence:** the unequal-punishment case; the unequal-background case.
- **Distinction:** consistency against fairness of process against justice of the standard.
- **Criticism:** the mirror-image failure of substantive justice, which prevents a one-sided answer.

Original 2 · 10 marks

Question: "Merit is a moral entitlement." Examine this claim.

Independent model answer

Thesis. ANALYSIS: The claim conflates two criteria operating in opposite temporal directions, and it is false as stated.

The distinction. FACT: **Desert** is backward-looking and moralised: it tracks what a person has done, sacrificed or suffered, and governs honours, recognition, praise and blame. FACT: **Merit** is forward-looking and functional: it tracks who will discharge a role well, and governs offices and appointments. ANALYSIS: A candidate may have great desert

and little merit, or great merit and no desert.

Why the conflation matters. ANALYSIS: Treating merit as a moral entitlement converts a claim about *fitness for a task* into a claim about *what is owed*.

The strongest objection to merit itself. FACT: Measured merit encodes prior access to nutrition, language, coaching and networks, so a selection score is partly a record of others' investment. ANALYSIS: Rawls presses further: natural talent, family advantage and even the capacity for effort are **morally arbitrary**, since nobody deserves the starting position from which effort is exerted.

The reply. FACT: Rawls does not conclude that desert is meaningless. Legitimate expectations generated **within** just institutions remain valid, and honour and gratitude remain intelligible responses to effort. ANALYSIS: What collapses is desert's claim to be *foundational*.

Verdict. ANALYSIS: Merit justifies selection for a role, not the rewards attached to it. The claim survives only in the weakened form that within fair institutions, expectations built on merit deserve protection.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus: "examine" invites you to find the equivocation. Name it in the second line.

- **Structure:** thesis -> the temporal distinction -> why the conflation matters -> objection -> reply -> weakened verdict.
- **Doctrine:** desert against merit; moral arbitrariness; legitimate expectations.
- **Evidence:** the encoded-advantage argument; Rawls's arbitrariness premise.
- **Distinction:** fitness for a task against what a person is owed.
- **Criticism:** the reply that rescues desert inside institutions while denying it foundational status.

Original 3 · 15 marks

Question: "An un-interfered-with dependant is nevertheless unfree." Critically discuss this claim and its consequences for the relation between law and liberty.

Independent model answer

Thesis. ANALYSIS: The claim is correct and it reverses the standard account of law: if freedom is a **secured standing** rather than an event-count, then non-arbitrary law constitutes freedom instead of subtracting from it.

The argument. ANALYSIS: The negative conception measures freedom by *actual* interference. Consider a person under a kind master, an indulgent husband or a benevolent ruler who happens not to interfere. She is not interfered with, so on the negative count she is free. Yet she must flatter, anticipate, self-censor and live at another's discretion, because the other retains the capacity to interfere **arbitrarily and with impunity**. That dependence is a real unfreedom an interference-count cannot register. Freedom is therefore best specified as **non-domination (Pettit, 1997; historical recovery, Skinner, 1998)**.

The controlling distinction. ANALYSIS: Interference is an **act**; domination is a **standing capacity** to interfere arbitrarily. Law that tracks the avowable interests of those it governs and remains publicly contestable can **interfere without dominating**; a master's forbearance can **dominate without interfering**.

The consequence for law. ANALYSIS: On the negative view, every law is *prima facie* a subtraction from liberty. On the republican view, law of the right kind is **freedom-constituting**, because it strips private persons of arbitrary power. FACT: The Bonded Labour System (Abolition) Act, **1976** illustrates the *form* of such a remedy by attacking a relation of personal dependence. ANALYSIS: Enactment is not implementation.

First objection and reply. CAUTION: Everything non-domination names could be redescribed as a high **probability** of future interference. ANALYSIS: But probability is contingent and can be low precisely where dependence is total; and the republican account additionally explains why the dependant's own conduct changes.

Second objection and reply. CAUTION: Who decides which interferences are arbitrary? ANALYSIS: Republicans answer procedurally: interference is non-arbitrary when it tracks the avowable interests of the governed and remains open to contestation. CAUTION: This reduces but does not remove the indeterminacy.

Verdict. ANALYSIS: The claim stands, the reversal of the law-liberty relation follows, and the residual indeterminacy of "arbitrary" is a genuine cost that should be conceded rather than concealed.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus: the consequence for law is the second half of the stem and is where most scripts stop short.

- **Structure:** thesis -> six-step argument -> act against standing -> consequence for law with a dated illustration -> two objection-reply pairs -> qualified verdict.
- **Doctrine:** non-domination; freedom-constituting law.
- **Evidence:** the benevolent-master case; Pettit (1997) and Skinner (1998); the 1976 Act as a form of remedy.
- **Distinction:** interference as act against domination as capacity.
- **Criticism:** redundancy and indeterminacy, both answered and the second only partly.

Original 4 · 15 marks

Question: Compare Berlin and Green on the meaning of liberty, and assess whether their positions can be reconciled.

Independent model answer

Thesis. ANALYSIS: Berlin and Green fear different failures, and their positions are reconcilable at the level of institutional design while remaining opposed at the level of authorisation.

The axis of dispute. ANALYSIS: The question is not how much freedom each wants but **what destroys it**. Berlin's anxiety is coercion exercised in the name of a higher freedom; Green's is formal liberty accompanied by no power to use it.

Berlin at full strength. FACT: Negative liberty asks within what area a person is left alone; positive liberty asks who governs her and by what self she is directed. FACT: Berlin does not deny the appeal of self-mastery; he identifies the step that makes it dangerous - the split between a "real self" and an "empirical self", after which a ruler may claim to speak for the first and present coercion as liberation. FACT: His background commitment is **value pluralism**: human goods are many and not always harmonisable.

Green at full strength. FACT: Liberty is the **positive power** to do or enjoy something worth doing or enjoying, tied to self-realisation. FACT: Mere non-interference is hollow where persons are crippled by ignorance, addiction, destitution or social subordination, so coercion is not freedom's only enemy: disabling conditions also matter. ANALYSIS: Education is the standing example, because it equips agency rather than merely leaving persons alone.

The reconciliation. ANALYSIS: The two are compatible if positive freedom is read as **enabling** rather than **perfectionist**: institutions may enlarge a person's effective capacity while leaving the choice of ends with her. On that reading Green supplies what Berlin's negative pole omits, and Berlin supplies the constraint Green's programme needs.

Where reconciliation fails. CAUTION: It fails at authorisation. If any agency is empowered to identify what is "worth doing", the real-self structure reappears, and no agreed test separates enablement from prescription in contested cases.

Verdict. ANALYSIS: Reconcilable in policy and irreconcilable in principle: keep the enabling programme and refuse the authorisation, accepting that the boundary must be policed by contestability and reversibility rather than by definition.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus: "compare and assess" needs shared axes, not two portraits. Fix the axis - what destroys freedom - in the second line.

- **Structure:** thesis -> axis -> Berlin at strength -> Green at strength -> reconciliation -> its failure point -> verdict.
- **Doctrine:** negative and positive liberty; enabling against perfectionist freedom.
- **Evidence:** the real-self split; value pluralism; the education case.
- **Distinction:** enlarging capacity against prescribing ends.
- **Criticism:** the authorisation problem, which blocks a complete reconciliation.

Original 5 · 20 marks

Question: Examine the claim that compensatory measures for historically disadvantaged groups are required by equality rather than being exceptions to it.

Independent model answer

Thesis. ANALYSIS: The claim is defensible once equality is read as equality of **prospects** rather than of rules, but it carries two burdens its defenders often ignore: a factual premise about transmission, and a statable terminus.

The starting point. FACT: Aristotle's corrective justice is **transactional**: it restores an arithmetic balance between two parties after a wrongful gain or loss, without regard to their merit. It presupposes an identifiable wrongdoer, an identifiable victim and a discrete transaction.

The extension problem. ANALYSIS: Structural disadvantage satisfies none of the three cleanly. The harm is cumulative, the beneficiaries diffuse, and the wrong embedded in institutions rather than in a single act. The compensatory principle is therefore an **extension** of corrective justice, not an application of it.

The reconstructed argument. ANALYSIS: (i) A group has suffered systematic, historically identifiable and legally sanctioned exclusion from land, education, office and honour. (ii) That exclusion continues to depress present **capability**, transmitting through wealth, networks, schooling, health and social confidence. (iii) Formal equality applied from today onward therefore **ratifies** an unequal starting line rather than correcting it. (iv) Corrective justice, generalised from transactions to structures, requires positive measures offsetting the transmitted disadvantage. (v) Compensatory measures are consequently demanded **by** equality, not as an exception to it.

The Indian frame, accurately classified. FACT: Articles 14 to 16 establish equality before the law, prohibition of discrimination and equality of opportunity in public employment, and Articles 15 and 16 contain **enabling clauses** permitting special provision for specified disadvantaged classes. **ANALYSIS:** An enabling clause is a **permission**, not a justification. **ANALYSIS:** The affirmative-action policy debate belongs to another owner and is deliberately not developed here.

First objection and reply. CAUTION: Compensation imposes a cost on present individuals who committed no wrong, and treats persons as group-members. **ANALYSIS:** The reply is that they are not alleged to be guilty but to be **unjustly advantaged** by a continuing distribution; and where disadvantage was inflicted group-wise, an individualised remedy cannot reach it.

Second objection and reply. CAUTION: Compensation has no natural terminus. **ANALYSIS:** The principle supplies its own: it lapses when the transmitted disadvantage it targets no longer operates. Refusal to measure that condition is a policy failure, not a defect of the principle.

Residual difficulty. CAUTION: Over-inclusion of the already-advantaged within a beneficiary group is real, and the transmission premise is factual and must be argued.

Verdict. ANALYSIS: Required by equality, on the prospects reading, and only while the transmission it targets can be shown to operate.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus: "examine" rewards finding the hidden premises. Name the factual premise and the terminus problem before the objections arrive.

- **Structure:** thesis -> transactional starting point -> extension problem -> five-step reconstruction -> Indian frame with classification -> two objection-reply pairs -> residual difficulty -> bounded verdict.
- **Doctrine:** corrective justice generalised; equality of prospects.
- **Evidence:** transmission through wealth, networks, schooling, health and confidence; Articles 14-16 and the enabling clauses.
- **Distinction:** constitutional permission against philosophical justification; guilt against unjust advantage.
- **Criticism:** over-inclusion and the unargued transmission premise, both conceded.

Original 6 · 20 marks

Question: "Formal equality is either empty or ideological." Assess this claim with reference to Mill and Marx.

Independent model answer

Thesis. ANALYSIS: The claim is half right. Formal equality is neither empty nor merely ideological, but it is **insufficient**, and Mill and Marx diagnose its insufficiency at two different depths.

What formal equality actually secures. FACT: Equality before the law and equal protection of the laws establish the rule against legal privilege by status, and this is a genuine achievement rather than a decorative one: without it, substantive measures lose the standard by which they can themselves be criticised. ANALYSIS: Its weakness is that it can be perfectly satisfied in a society that remains radically unequal - the objection that it can become **paper equality**.

Mill's diagnosis - the social depth. FACT: Mill affirms equal moral standing and equality before the law, and then carries equality beyond formal rights into social relations. FACT: His central case is *The Subjection of Women* (1869), where the legal and social subordination of women is treated as a relic of domination; the appeal to women's "nature" is disqualified as evidence because that nature has been socially manufactured through subjection. ANALYSIS: But his remedy stops at reform of property and labour conditions and refuses coercive equalisation, because the aim of removing hierarchy is to release **individuality**, not to impose uniformity.

Marx's diagnosis - the material depth. FACT: Marx holds that formally equal exchange can conceal material exploitation: the wage contract appears free and equal between legal equals while class power shapes production and appropriation. FACT: Hence an **equal right can be a right of inequality**, because a common standard applied to persons differing in need, burden and starting position guarantees unequal effect. FACT: The corrective is **equity** - differentiated treatment answering to actual condition - expressed in the *Critique of the Gotha Programme* formula, "from each according to his ability, to each according to his need". ANALYSIS: The formula is indexed to a higher stage of social cooperation and is not a market-time salary rule.

Adjudication. ANALYSIS: Mill shows that formal equality is socially incomplete; Marx shows that it may be structurally complicit. The second is the stronger charge and the more speculative, since the two-stage structure is a normative projection rather than a demonstrated law. ANALYSIS: Neither thinker establishes that formal equality is **empty**: both rely on it when identifying the subordination and the exploitation they condemn.

Verdict. ANALYSIS: Formal equality is a necessary and insufficient condition of equality proper - indispensable as a constraint, misleading as a completed ideal, and ideological only when presented as the whole of what equality demands.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus: the quoted claim contains two accusations. Separate "empty" from "ideological" and rule on each.

- **Structure:** split the claim -> what formal equality secures -> Mill's diagnosis -> Marx's diagnosis -> adjudication -> verdict.
 - **Doctrine:** formal equality; social subordination; equity as need-sensitivity.
 - **Evidence:** *The Subjection of Women* (1869); the manufactured-nature argument; the Gotha formula; the appearance of freedom in the wage contract.
 - **Distinction:** socially incomplete against structurally complicit.
 - **Criticism:** the speculative status of the two-stage projection, and the fact that both critics themselves rely on formal equality.
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